At the risk of boring the reader with more names of pioneering Orientalists I must add another, also a Scot: James Fergusson, who having made enough money from indigo to be able to retire while still in his mid-twenties chose to reinvent himself as an architectural historian.

Fergusson had become fascinated by one particular form of architecture that he had first explored in and around the great natural harbour of Bombay, visiting the cave on Elephanta Island with its huge Shaiva carvings and the Buddhist caves at Kanheri, now located within the Sanjay National Park on the northern outskirts of the Mumbai megalopolis. Fergusson was also aware of two other cave complexes that had recently come to public attention: the great horse-shoe of rock-cut caves at Ajanta, with their mouldering but still exquisite wall paintings, and the Hindu rock-cut temples at Ellora, both in Maratha country.

These elaborately carved-out caves, dug out of solid rock, had struck him as being uniquely Indian. They were being spoken of as ‘cave-temples’, but Fergusson gave them the more precise name of ‘rock-cut caves’. Determined to make them his object of study, Fergusson sailed to England, learned all he could about the principles of architecture, and returned to India in 1838. He then spent the next five years zig-zagging across the country, beginning in the Western Ghats and working his way down the coast as far as Mahabalipuram, south of Madras.

What Fergusson was unaware of when he embarked on his study was that this was another of the innovations begun in Emperor Ashoka’s time, after which rock-cutting spread very rapidly to virtually every corner of India wherever the local geology lent itself naturally to this form of excavation. There are well over a thousand such artificial caves scattered across the Indian subcontinent, of which the majority are at least two thousand years old. They extend from Jain caves in the hills around Madurai to the Buddhist